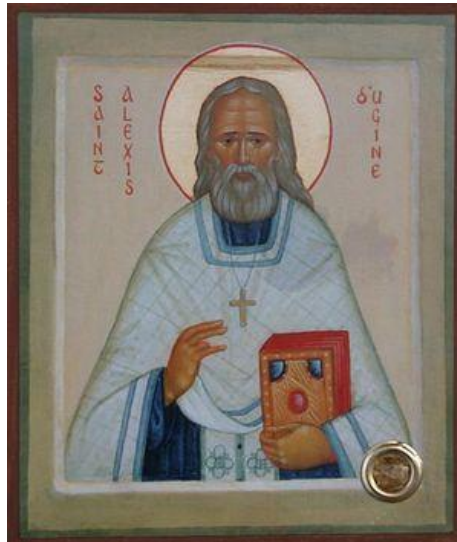


THE RIGHTEOUS ALEXEI MEDVEDKOV (of Ugine)

May we emulate his endurance and simplicity! Also: why take the blessing of a priest?

Commemorated August 9/22

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 13th Sunday after Pentecost. Aug 29/ Sep 11, 2022



http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-09-11+13th-sun-after-pentecost+rightious-alexei-of-ugine.docx

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-09-11+13th-sun-after-pentecost+rightious-alexei-of-ugine.pdf

I have another name to add to the list of saints that I asked for prayers every day. I have been reading the same Synaxarion (<https://sebastianpress.org/the-synaxarion-the-lives-of-the-saints-of-the-orthodox-church-complete-set/>) day by day for three years, and I've read about St. Alexei before but it didn't register with me. This is why it is very good to read certain good books over and over because you always learn something new. Among those good books I would count the Gospels, the Psalter, the lives of the saints (Synaxarion), the Ladder of Divine Ascent, and of course all of the Bible.



The holy Archpriest Alexei was just a regular old Parish priest, if it is possible to be such a priest when Communism and Bolshevism was persecuting the church with unholy vigor. I suppose there's really no such thing as a regular old parish priest in any place or time because the things that a priest does are not regular at all. St Kosmas Aitolos teaches that a priest being midway between being a man and being an angel. That is of course his office! That might not be his personality!

St Alexei was born in 1861, so that he was raised in a life of piety, but the country was falling apart at that time. It took a while for the revolution to occur, but the seeds of the revolution were planted at least 200 years beforehand. He went to a seminary and he was not sure about becoming a priest so he consulted no less than Saint John of Kronstadt, who gave him his blessing to serve as a priest.

The Blessing of a priest.

I want to say something about the blessing of a priest. Of course, St John was a holy man and we know him as a saint. And I'm not a holy man but I have the same amount of fingers on my right hand as St John does. Oftentimes when we ask the blessing of a priest God seals our intent with grace. It doesn't matter if the priest is a good guy or a bad guy. We are actually submitting ourselves to another human being and to God. We are also taking counsel of another human being. It's always good to take counsel from someone that we always know everything ourselves because we are so smart. We don't like those things very much in general. I'm convinced that, myself included, we all suffer from a narcissism. Of course, a true narcissist (as psychologists define) is impossible to communicate with or deal with, but those of us who have a touch of it. We don't want to submit to others very much. We also, lamentably, sometimes get proud if somebody says something nasty to us, or we don't want to do something because it doesn't appeal to us, etc.

I've had the experience of a person asking me for a blessing to commit to stop smoking. And of course, I would bless this! So, I said "May God bless you." That is all. And of course, I pray for this person every day and my prayers are poor, but they are the prayers of a priest. I never specifically prayed that this person would quit smoking but God had given the blessing through the hands of me an unworthy priest. And this person never smoked again, and doesn't have the desire to do so anymore.

There is nothing holy about me. But there is something holy about submitting to an unholy person and asking for a blessing! And of course, I cannot give blessings, but God gives them through the hand of a priest. I think we should consider that asking a blessing of a priest for even a mundane task like quitting smoking or going on a trip or something else is a way of conquering our personal narcissism and our pride. It is a prayer. We are beseeching God, through the hand of a priest, to bless us. God loves to bless his people through his priests and through any of his people.

Of course, a priest who has any sense about him, and I do have a little bit of sense, does not believe that he can give blessings willy-nilly to people and that they must always do what he tells them, and not do what he does not bless. Of course, that's stupid ;that's cultish. All we are doing when we are asking for a blessing from a priest is asking God to seal our intent with his grace. God can give his grace anyway He wishes. He chooses to give his grace through the blessings of a priest, and by many other means. We should not ignore this avenue by which God chooses to give His grace to us.

Father Alexis married and was ordained a priest in 1895 and was serving near St Petersburg. He was a very active and energetic priest, beloved by his flock, and very active in ministry, even though he had to farm the land and do many other jobs because of his poverty.

With the coming of the Revolution, he was arrested by the Bolsheviks very early, in 1918. He was 50 years old. In prison, he was tortured, his arms and legs broken, a nerve in his face torn and finally he was scourged and sentenced to death. However, extraordinarily, his eldest daughter gave herself up as a hostage and the

ageing priest was released. The trace of these events remained on Fr Alexis' face for the rest of his life; he lost the use of a facial nerve and his right eye was always open wider than his left¹.

He immigrated to Estonia and was very poor. He first worked in her sleep mine alongside shackled criminals. The work was exhausting and in time he was given a surface job as a night watchman. Despite his exhausting labors, and his physical pains, he was very active in priestly ministry and organized a little parish and was especially interested in teaching the children. In 1930 his wife died, so he moved with his two daughters and his grandson to France.

In our Parish we have led a rather sheltered life. We've always been very calm and there hasn't been dissension. There's a term for a certain parishes, they are called "priest killer parishes." Our parish has always been a "priest nurturer parish." I thank God for that. I've always been free to be me, to administer the parish without complaints and enjoy the great support of well over 99% of the people that have passed through our doors.

Father Alexis did not have the same peace amongst his people that I have enjoyed. He served long services and dressed very simply. He probably preached somewhat long sermons! Hmm, that reminds me of somebody: I guess I'm a little bit like saint! 😊 The people complained to the bishop about him. They wanted things to be easy and short, and most likely they didn't like his sermons because they were actually about Christianity. He was summoned to the bishop and the bishop realized very soon that the demeanor of Father Alexis was that of a simple humble and pious priest and he replaced the church council. In our day, just as in that day, this is not always the case! There are churches where the Church Council reigns supreme. Thank God that we have a Church Council where we just discuss things and there's never been an acrimonious meeting.

In France, Fr Alexis served liturgy every single day. I am in awe of that exploit! He was very poor and I have no doubts that he served liturgies in which there might have been one or two people present. That is impressive to me, as a priest. I have also served some liturgies where one or two people were present. To do this over the course of years is very difficult. It takes great faith and humility. And I don't have either one of those. Even if I do these things, perhaps sometimes I'm a little cynical about things or a little unhappy. I have no doubts that Fr Alexis did these things with humility. And he never lost an opportunity to gather the children around him and to speak to them about God.

He certainly had all the virtues but without a very important virtue that we don't often speak of very much, his ministry would not come to anything because he would've given up. His endurance is what impresses me the most. I think endurance comes first of all from believing in something completely, but also from following that which we believe completely and prioritizing our life so that we always try to do the things that contribute to the things that we say we believe!

Father Alexis developed intestinal cancer and died in 1934. Before his death, while he was confined to bed, a parishioner who loved him visited him many times and we fortunately have these words of the saint:

“In my parish the true parishioners are the children, the children of my parishioners ... and if those children live and grow up, they will form the inner Church. And we too, we belong to that Church, as long as we live according to our conscience and fulfil the commandments ... do you understand what I mean? In the visible Church there is an invisible Church, a secret Church. In it are found the humble who live by grace and walk in the will of God. They can be found in every parish and every jurisdiction. The emigration lives through them and by the grace of God”.

After his death the doctor was afraid that his body would decompose so he was buried immediately. Twenty years later his body was exhumed and the workmen found it intact along with the liturgical vestments. There have been many miracles associated with his relics in his prayers.

May God help us poor ones to pay attention to our inner life! Through the prayers of St. Alexis, may we learn to live with attention to God’s commandments and endurance in fulfilling them matter what happens.

Recent Stuff:

[Can a government make a proclamation of independence from the ruling hierarch of the Orthodox church in their country?](#)

Video: https://youtu.be/_jbkWx5nndA

Video: <https://rumble.com/v1jujt9-can-a-government-proclaim-independence-from-the-ruling-hierarch-of-the-church.html>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022-09-11+latvian-government-proclaims-independence-from-russian-church.mp3

A question from our catechism class: “Does the Latvian government have the authority to declare independence of the Latvian Orthodox Church from the Moscow?” As is our custom, we answer much more than just this question. This is a question of who we are and to whom we should be obedient. It is a question of when we should disobey our bishop and separate from him. It is a question of who should we be praying for and should we be praying for one or another combatant to be victorious in Ukraine or should we be praying for a stable peace as God desires it? What are the dangers to the church in Ukraine, that is the true Orthodox Christians in Ukraine? What can the little guy do?

As is always the case in any question about world politics or anything that happens in the world, our personal reaction to it must be a spiritual one first and must involve prayer for those we support in those we oppose. Every church should be praying for both Ukraine and Russia. Especially Ukrainian churches should be praying for Russia as well as their country, and Russian churches can be praying for Ukraine as well as their country. We also, from her tiny little pulpit, patriarch Curiel and Metropolitan Onuphrius to get together and celebrate the liturgy as brothers, and not allow political rhetoric and the fog of war to obscure the fact that they are in brothers.

[Martyrs Adrian and Natalia: Perfection with imperfect steps. Comm Aug 26](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-08-26_2022+martyrs-adrian-and-natalia.mp3

The glorious “bloodless” martyr Natalia was a secret Christian, and married to a pagan! And her husband Adrian became inspired by the exploits, endurance, and dignity of Christians being martyred, and she then made known to him her Christianity and assisted him during his martyrdom in an intimate way. We talk about this, how perfection came from imperfect beginnings. Len 9:23

[Baptism of Iwerwdd \(pronounced: Oo-airith\)/ Aerith: What did we do and why? What was symbolic or actual? Why the incarnation? What should we do now?](#)

Video: <https://youtu.be/iA9vk8Gm5X0>

Video: <https://rumble.com/v1iz87l-baptism-of-erith-what-did-we-do-and-why-what-was-symbolic-or-actual-why-the.html>

Audio: <http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/baptism-2022+iwerwdd+overview-of-baptism-the-incarnation-our-purpose.mp3>

Timestamps:

0:00 – 1:26 Symbolism of churcing the infant and leaving her on the ground before the royal doors.

1:26 – 4:35 What did we do today? Why did Jesus become incarnate, And what is spiritual death?

1:56 What does this mean: “Gen 3:3 But of the fruit of the tree which is in the midst of the garden, God hath said, Ye shall not eat of it, neither shall ye touch it, lest ye die.”

16:11 – 07:16 What Erith’s purpose?

07:16 – 08:18 What symbolically and actually happened in Erith’s baptism?

8:18 – 08:47 What is symbolic and actual about processing 3 times around the font during the baptism service

[The Dormition of the Theotokos. Another lesson about the power of the resurrection.](#)

Video: <https://youtu.be/Fm4RASgyRCo>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/dormition_2022.mp3

What is the Dormition, and does this feast apply to *us*? It is impossible to understand the incarnation and the resurrection without understanding the role of Mary. Why do we believe the Dormition is true? How was the bible written? Why do we call Mary the Theotokos? Exegesis of the Magnificat, which is partially read on feasts of Mary, the Theotokos.

Partial timestamps:

00:00 – 01:35 Meaning of “Dormition” – regarding the Feast of the Dormition and Christian experience after the resurrection

01:35 – 03:51 Why do we believe the Dormition is true? How was the bible written? What is the main way the church teaches her children?

03:51 – 6:23 and 10:30 – 11:34 Meaning of the word “Theotokos”, and “Christotokos”, and why the distinction is important. And whether or not we should be well educated on all the heresies regarding the incarnation.

6:23 – 10:30 A short explanation of the reason for the incarnation.

11:33 – 13:04 Why is the supper with Mary and Martha read on feasts of the Theotokos?

15:10 – 19:35 “And it came to pass, that, when Elisabeth heard the salutation of Mary, the babe leaped in her womb;”

19:35 – end The “Magnificat”

20:55 – 24:53 “And Mary said, My soul doth magnify the Lord, And my spirit hath rejoiced in God my Saviour. For he hath regarded the low estate of his slave: for, behold, from henceforth all generations shall call me blessed. For he that is mighty hath done to me great things; and holy is his name.”

(Luke 1:46-49)

24:53 “And his mercy is on them that fear him from generation to generation.” (Luke 1:50)

¹ “Alexius (Mededkov) of Ugine, archpriest, righteous”, <https://stjohndc.org/en/list-of-relics/alexius-mededkov-ugine-archpriest-righteous>